

Dehydration & ORS: rehydrate early, know danger signs

Dehydration can become dangerous fast, especially for babies, young children, older adults, and people who are ill. **Oral rehydration solution (ORS)** replaces water and salts more effectively than plain water when dehydration risk is high.

SEEK URGENT MEDICAL HELP NOW

Get urgent help for lethargy, confusion, unconsciousness, seizures, inability to drink or keep fluids down, repeated vomiting, blood in stool, severe belly pain, signs of severe dehydration, symptoms in a very young infant, or any person who is getting worse despite rehydration. Use local emergency services when needed.

Use packaged ORS if available

Use commercially prepared ORS packets when you can. Mix exactly as directed on the packet, using safe water and the full amount of water listed. Too little water can make the solution too salty; too much water can make it less effective.

If no packet is available: emergency home mix

MEASURE CAREFULLY

Only use a home mix when packaged ORS is not available and you can measure carefully.

- 1 liter safe water
- 6 level teaspoons sugar
- 1/2 level teaspoon salt

Stir until dissolved. The drink should taste no saltier than tears. If it tastes very salty, throw it away and mix again. Discard after 24 hours, or sooner if contaminated.

How to give fluids

- Give small, frequent sips. If vomiting occurs, wait 5–10 minutes and try again slowly.
- For infants and young children, use a spoon, cup, or syringe in small amounts often.
- Continue breastfeeding and normal age-appropriate feeding when possible.
- Do not give fluids by mouth to someone who is unconscious, very confused, unable to swallow safely, or having a seizure.
- Avoid alcohol. Avoid very sugary drinks as the main rehydration fluid during diarrhea; they can worsen diarrhea for some people.

For children: also give zinc

RECOMMENDED BY WHO & UNICEF

For a child with diarrhea, the WHO and UNICEF recommend giving **zinc every day for 10–14 days**, alongside ORS. Zinc shortens the illness, makes it less severe, and helps prevent diarrhea in the following months. The usual amount is **20 mg per day** for children, and **10 mg per day for infants under 6 months**. Use a zinc product made for children and follow the package or a health worker's instructions, and keep giving it for the full course even after the diarrhea stops.

Watch for dehydration

CONCERNING SIGNS

- Very thirsty, dry mouth, little or no urination
- Dizziness, weakness, fast heartbeat
- Sunken eyes, no tears in a child, unusual sleepiness
- Persistent diarrhea or vomiting

EMERGENCY SIGNS

- Very drowsy, confused, limp, or unconscious
- Unable to drink or breastfeed
- Repeated vomiting or signs getting worse
- Blood in stool, severe pain, or seizure

For caregivers and volunteers

- Ask age, symptoms, whether the person can drink, urine frequency, vomiting/diarrhea frequency, and whether blood is present.
- Prioritize urgent care for babies, older adults, pregnant people, people with chronic illness, and anyone getting worse.
- Do not diagnose the cause of diarrhea or vomiting. Help with safe fluids and escalation.
- Use safe water. If water safety is uncertain, follow local guidance for boiling, treating, or using sealed water.

Prevent the next illness

- **Wash hands with soap** after using the toilet or cleaning a child, and before preparing food or eating.
- **Use safe drinking water**, stored covered and clean; boil or treat water when its safety is uncertain.
- **Use a toilet or latrine** and dispose of stool, including children's, safely.
- **Vaccinate:** the rotavirus vaccine protects babies against a common, severe cause of diarrhea — ask your health service.

Sources

- World Health Organization (WHO) — oral rehydration salts and diarrhoeal disease guidance. [who.int](https://www.who.int)

- UNICEF — oral rehydration therapy and child diarrhea resources. [unicef.org](https://www.unicef.org)
- WHO/UNICEF — joint recommendation on zinc supplementation with ORS for childhood diarrhea. [who.int](https://www.who.int)
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — diarrhea and dehydration guidance for travelers, children, and emergencies. [cdc.gov](https://www.cdc.gov)
- MedlinePlus / U.S. National Library of Medicine — dehydration and oral rehydration information. [medlineplus.gov](https://www.nlm.nih.gov/medlineplus)

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for professional care. Local guidance may differ, especially for infants, cholera outbreaks, severe malnutrition, kidney/heart disease, or other medical conditions. When in doubt, seek medical help.